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ACADEMIC VAULT

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Sleep, Fitness and Posture: The Physical Habits Behind Good Grades

Small daily routines that protect memory, mood and your back

HEALTH & WELLBEING

Health & Wellbeing

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Sleep and movement are not luxuries to be traded for study hours - they are part of how learning is consolidated. This pack covers sleep hygiene, a no-equipment exercise routine, posture for long study sessions and recovering after late nights.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Explain the role of sleep in memory and mood.
- Apply sleep-hygiene practices in a hostel environment.
- Follow a simple weekly exercise routine without equipment.
- Correct posture during long study sessions and screen use.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Sleep is study time

Memory consolidation happens during sleep, so cutting sleep reduces what you keep.

- Adults need roughly seven to nine hours, with consistent timing.
- Sleep supports memory consolidation, emotional regulation and immune function.
- Caffeine after mid-afternoon and late-night screens delay sleep onset.
- All-nighters produce short-term recall but impair understanding and accuracy.
- A consistent wind-down routine signals the body to sleep.
- If you must sleep late, keep the wake time stable rather than shifting both.

> **After a late night**
> Prioritise a short recovery nap, daylight, water and a normal bedtime the next day. Sleeping all day resets your rhythm in the wrong direction.

Movement without a gym

Consistency matters more than intensity.

- Aim for 150 minutes of moderate activity per week, spread across days.
- Bodyweight basics: squats, push-ups (wall or floor), lunges, planks, glute bridges.
- Walking briskly to lectures counts as activity.
- Stretch hip flexors, hamstrings and chest after long sitting.
- Warm up for five minutes and progress gradually.
- Stop and seek advice if you feel chest pain, dizziness or joint injury.

Posture and screen habits

Long hours hunched over a phone affect neck, shoulders and concentration.

- Raise your screen to eye level and keep feet flat on the floor.
- Keep the lower back supported and elbows near 90 degrees.
- Follow the 20-20-20 rule: every 20 minutes, look 20 feet away for 20 seconds.
- Stand and move for two minutes every 45 to 60 minutes.
- Carry bags evenly or use a backpack with two straps.
- Do not study lying flat with a laptop on your chest.

Sleep is where learning is consolidated

Sleep is not lost time from study; it is part of studying. Memory consolidation happens during sleep, and sleep deprivation impairs attention, working memory and emotional regulation before it impairs anything you would notice subjectively. People who are sleep-deprived are reliably worse at judging how impaired they are.

The two practical levers are regularity and light. A consistent wake time stabilises the body clock more effectively than a consistent bedtime. Morning daylight and dim evening light reinforce the same rhythm; bright screens late at night do the opposite.

Caffeine has a half-life of about five hours, which means a 4 p.m. coffee still has a quarter of its effect at midnight. Alcohol helps people fall asleep and then fragments sleep in the second half of the night.

Movement you will actually do